

The weight of the Azteca

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For Mexico, the World Cup will not creep into view. It will arrive with noise, altitude and memory.

On June 11, when Mexico walks out at the Estadio Azteca, it will be doing more than opening the 2026 World Cup. It will be carrying a nation's expectations into a ground that has already witnessed Pele, Diego Maradona, two World Cup finals and some of football's most enduring images. This time, the stage belongs to Mexico again, and so does the burden.

The host nation has lived for decades with a familiar World Cup contradiction: too strong to be ignored, yet not strong enough to break through. Mexico has regularly survived the group stage but has not crossed the quarterfinal barrier since doing so on home soil in 1986. Now, with the tournament returning to its backyard, Javier Aguirre's side has the kind of

opportunity that can either elevate a generation or weigh it down.

Aguirre, in his third spell as head coach, has been brought back for control, clarity and tournament experience. Mexico's spine possesses plenty of it. Guillermo Ochoa remains part of the conversation, Edson Alvarez gives the midfield its edge, while Raul Jimenez and Santiago Gimenez offer two different interpretations of the No. 9 role. Around them, Julian Quinones, Cesar Huerta and Alexis Vega provide pace and directness.

The group offers Mexico a genuine chance to finish top, but it is far from straightforward. Its

opening match against South Africa should be won, especially with the noise and altitude of Mexico City behind it. But the second game against Korea Republic in Guadalajara could shape the group. If Mexico tops Group A, it will face one of the best third-placed teams from Groups C, E, F, H or I in the round of 32. If it finishes second, it will meet the runner-up



MEXICO

FIFA Ranking: 15

Appearances: 17

Best finish: Quarterfinals (1970, 1986)

Matches: 60

Wins: 17

Draws: 15

Losses: 28

Goals For: 62

Goals Against: 101

Highest scorer in the squad

Raul Jimenez (44 goals)



KOREA REPUBLIC

FIFA Ranking: 25

Appearances: 11

Best finish: Fourth place (2002)

Matches: 38

Wins: 7

Draws: 10

Losses: 21

Goals For: 39

Goals Against: 78

Highest scorer in the squad

Son Heung-min (56 goals)

